A 90-MINUTE WORKSHOP

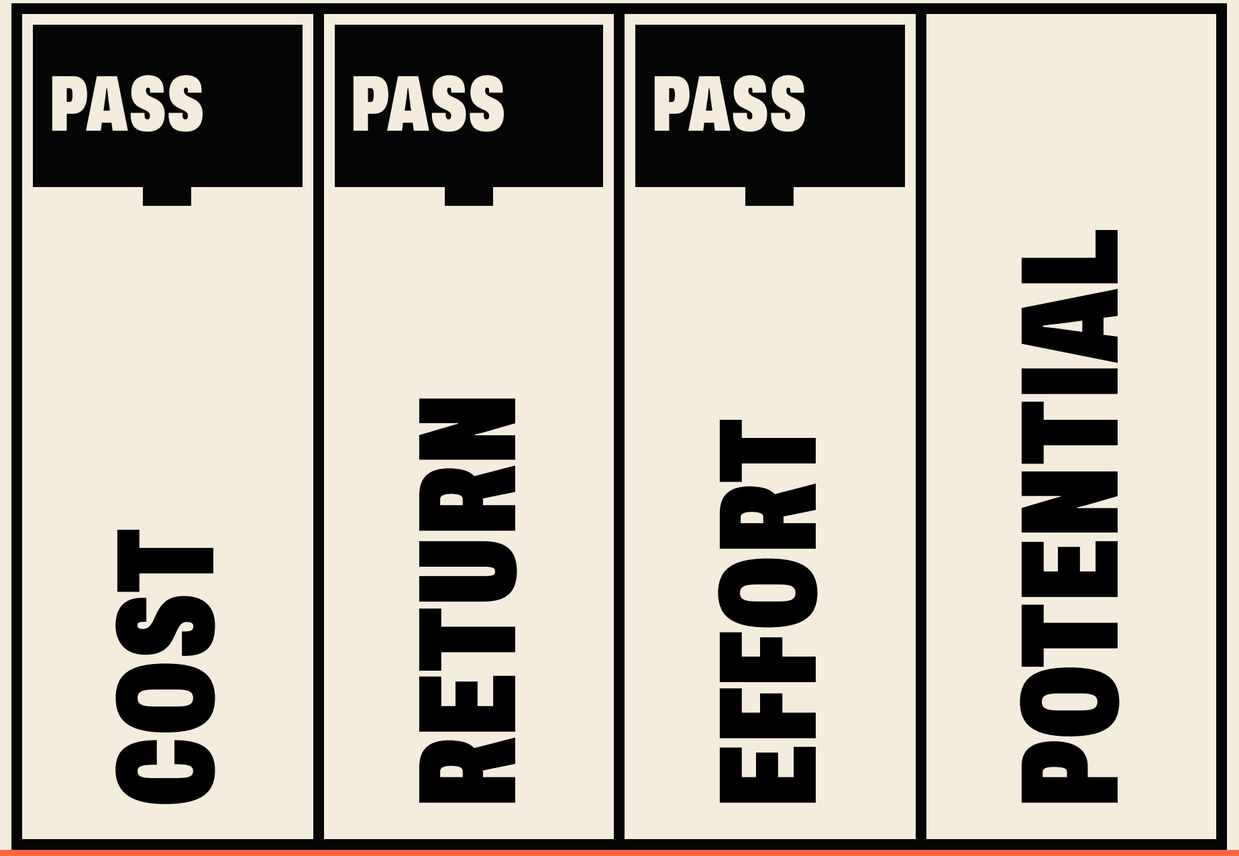
WAYPOINT · NOAI 2026 · NEW ORLEANS

THE MOST VALUABLE AI SKILL IS SAYING

Screening AI use cases for real return.

Dustin T Hughes

VP of Technology, Laborde Products



TAKE A WORKSHEET AND A PEN

STARTS **2:30**

YOUR BEST AI IDEA IS PROBABLY WRONG.

The boring one you didn't pitch is probably

WORTH THOUSANDS.

A 90-MINUTE WORKSHOP

THE MOST VALUABLE AI SKILL IS SAYING NO

Screening AI use cases for real return.

Dustin T Hughes

VP of Technology, Laborde Products

WAYPOINT · NOAI 2026 · NEW ORLEANS

WHEN	TIME	ROOM
FRIDAY NOV 13, 2026	2:30–4:00 PM 90 MINUTES	EDUCATION CENTER

“~~Information theory~~ AI OUR EDIT
has, in the last few years, become something of a scientific bandwagon.”

— CLAUDE SHANNON, THE BANDWAGON, 1956

1956.

“Seldom do more than a few of nature’s secrets give way at one time.”

— CLAUDE SHANNON, THE BANDWAGON, 1956

I say no for a living.

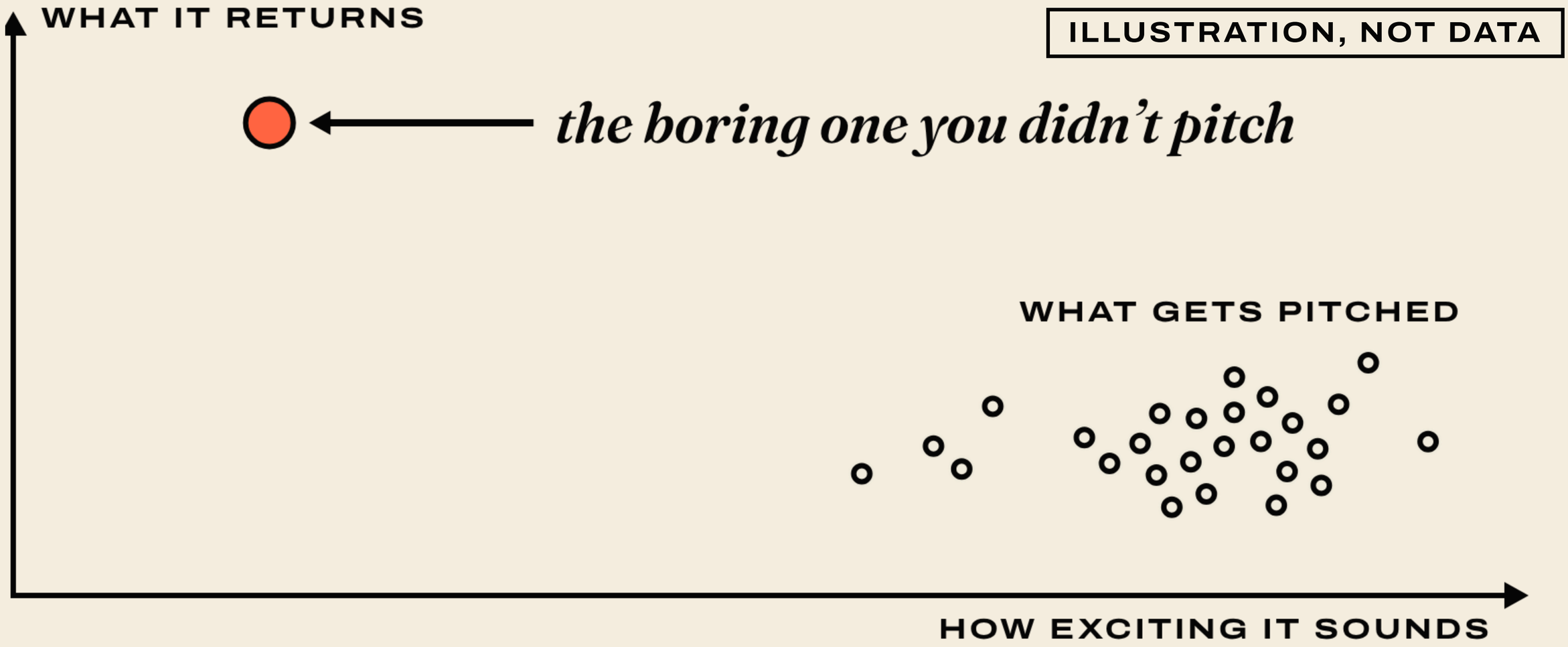
PEOPLE	LOCATIONS	BUILDING SOFTWARE	AI SINCE
95	3	25 years	2013

THE WAYPOINT STANDARD

1	2	3	4
THE TASK	THE PROMPT	THE OUTPUT	THE TIME SAVED

A win only counts with all four.

EXCITEMENT IS NOT A BUSINESS CASE.



Illustration, not data. The dots are made up to show a pattern. Nothing on this slide was measured.

IN THE NEXT 90 MINUTES

1 Inventory two weeks of real work

2 Pick three

3 Four gates

4 The math picks

5 Watch one get built

You leave with one use case worth doing, and two you can stop thinking about.

THE FOUR GATES

EXAMPLE

Any no ends it.

PASS

GATE 1

COST

What does it cost to run?



CARRIED FORWARD

GATE 2

RETURN

What comes back: cash sooner, or more work done?

NO

STOPS HERE

GATE 3

EFFORT

What does it take to build it and keep it alive?

NOT YET

GATE 4

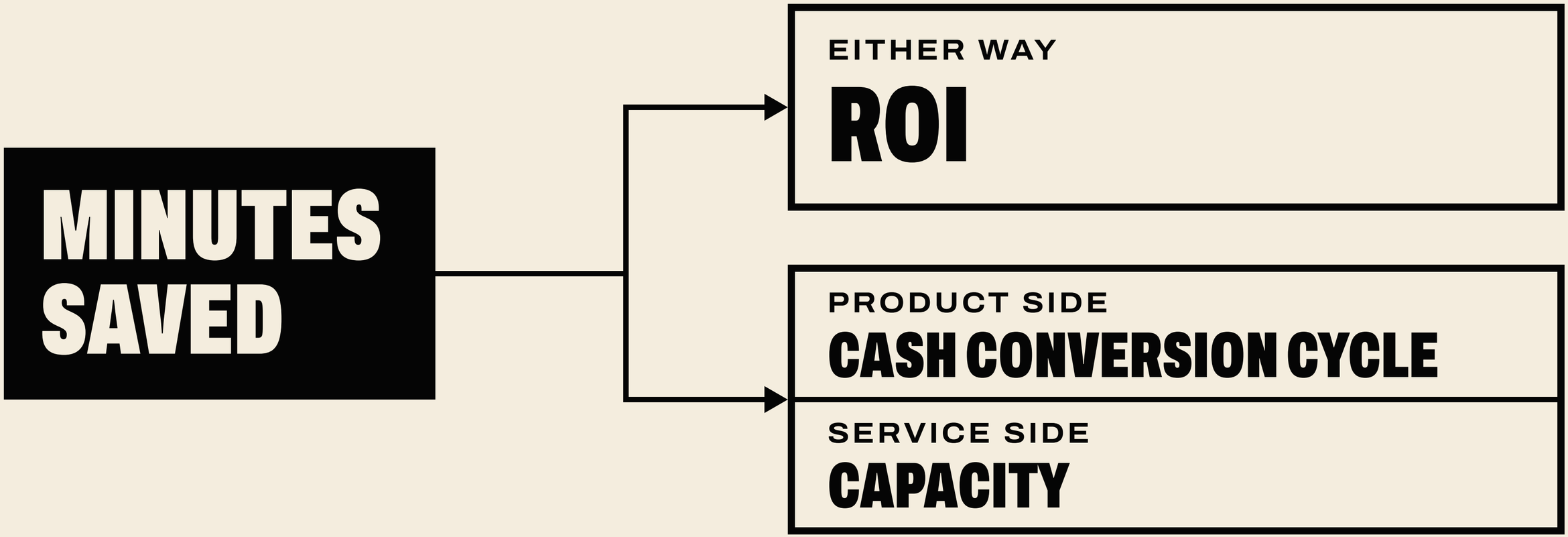
POTENTIAL

If it works, how far does it grow?

NOT YET

Minutes are the raw material.

Money is what they turn into.

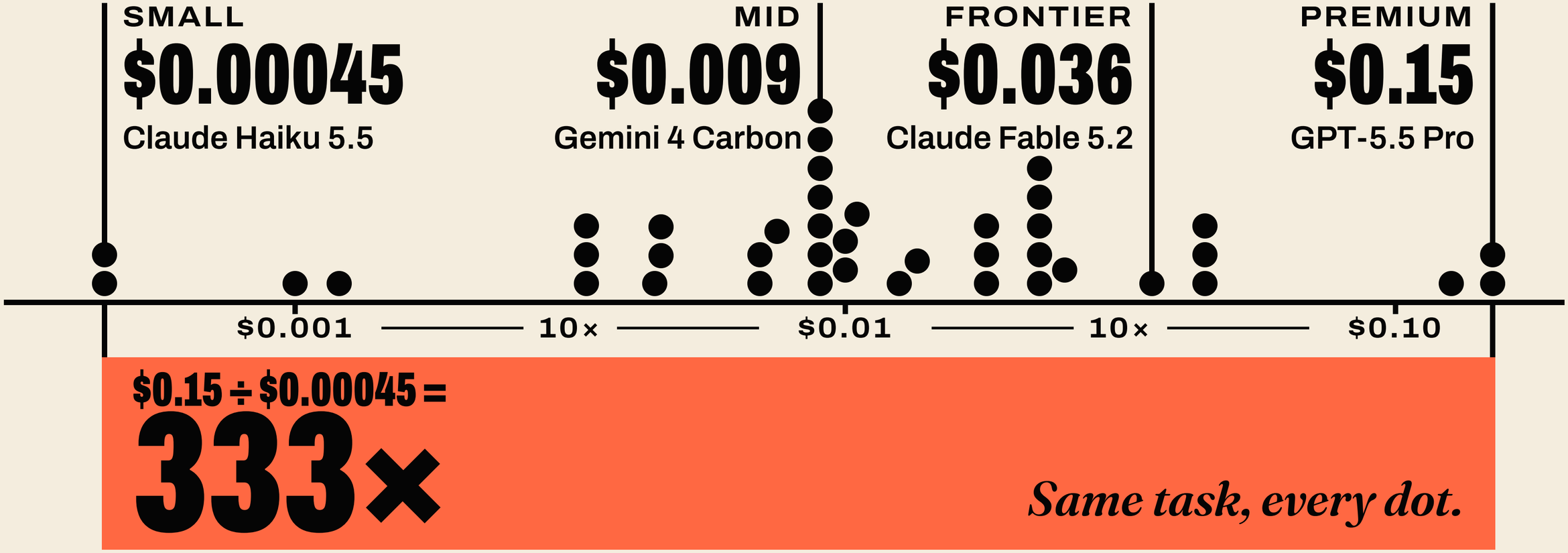


GATE 1 · COST

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

WHAT DOES IT COST TO RUN?

41 MODELS · PRICE PER TASK · 2,000 TOKENS IN, 500 OUT · LOG SCALE



$0.15 ÷ $0.00045 =

333×

Same task, every dot.

Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · 41 of 50 models priced (5 blank and 4 at $0 left out) · GPT-5.5 Pro and GPT-5.4 Pro tie at $0.15 · Claude Haiku 5.5 and GPT-6 Luna tie at $0.00045

FOR ONE PERSON, COST ALMOST NEVER SAYS NO.

18 seconds

what the dearest model has to save to pay for itself, at $30 an hour

EXAMPLE RATE · DRAG FROM $20 TO $150 AN HOUR

$30

FRONTIER MODEL

4.3 seconds

Claude Fable 5.2 · $0.036 a task

SMALL MODEL

0.05 seconds

Claude Haiku 5.5 · $0.00045 a task

Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · GPT-5.5 Pro and GPT-5.4 Pro tie at $0.15 · one task = 2,000 tokens in, 500 out

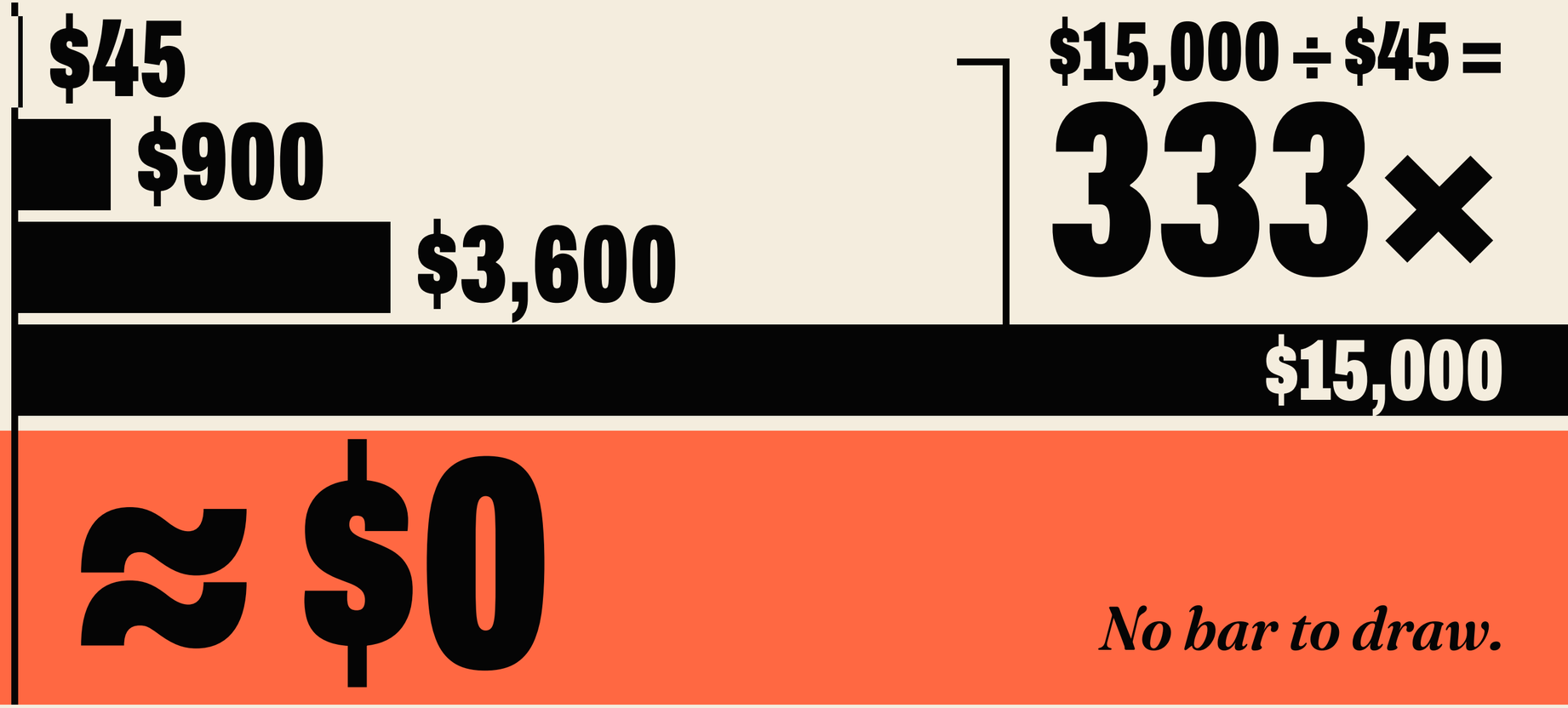
GATE 1 · COST · RECORD SCALE

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

100,000 RECORDS. SAME TASK.

1 | 1,000 | 100,000 | 1,000,000

COST OF THE WHOLE BATCH
US DOLLARS · DRAWN TO SCALE



PLAIN CODE

≈ $0

No bar to draw.

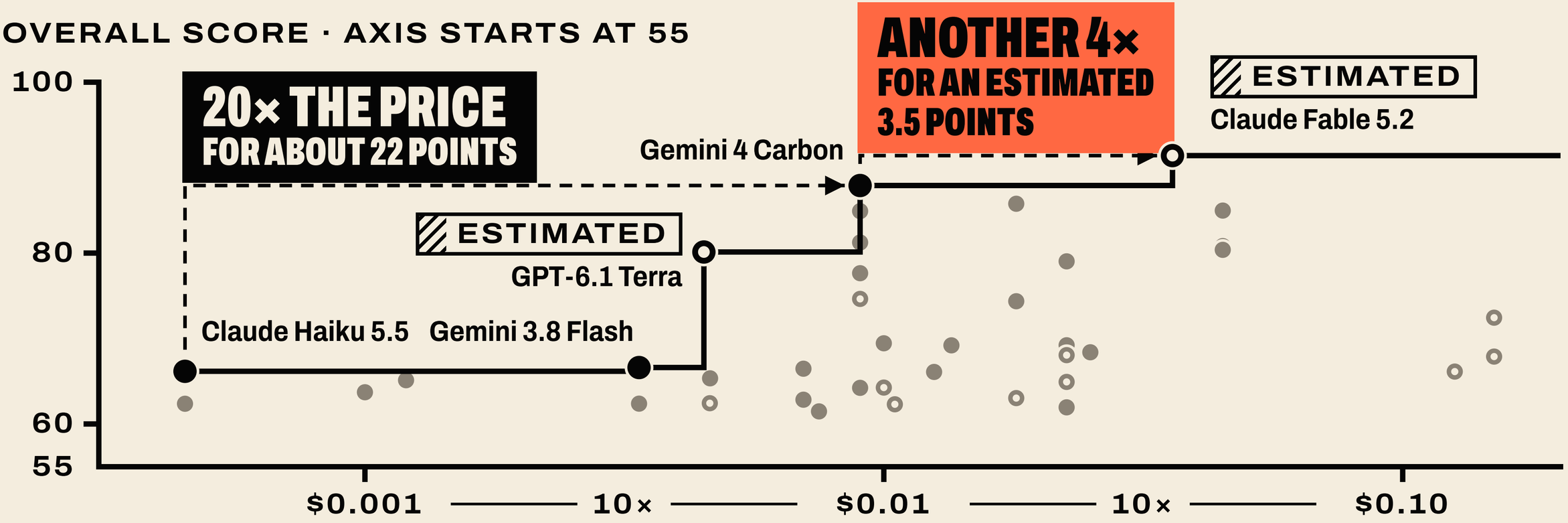
Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · one record = one task = 2,000 tokens in, 500 out

GATE 1 · COST · RECORD SCALE

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

36 OF 41 ARE BEATEN BY SOMETHING THAT COSTS THE SAME OR LESS.

OVERALL SCORE · AXIS STARTS AT 55



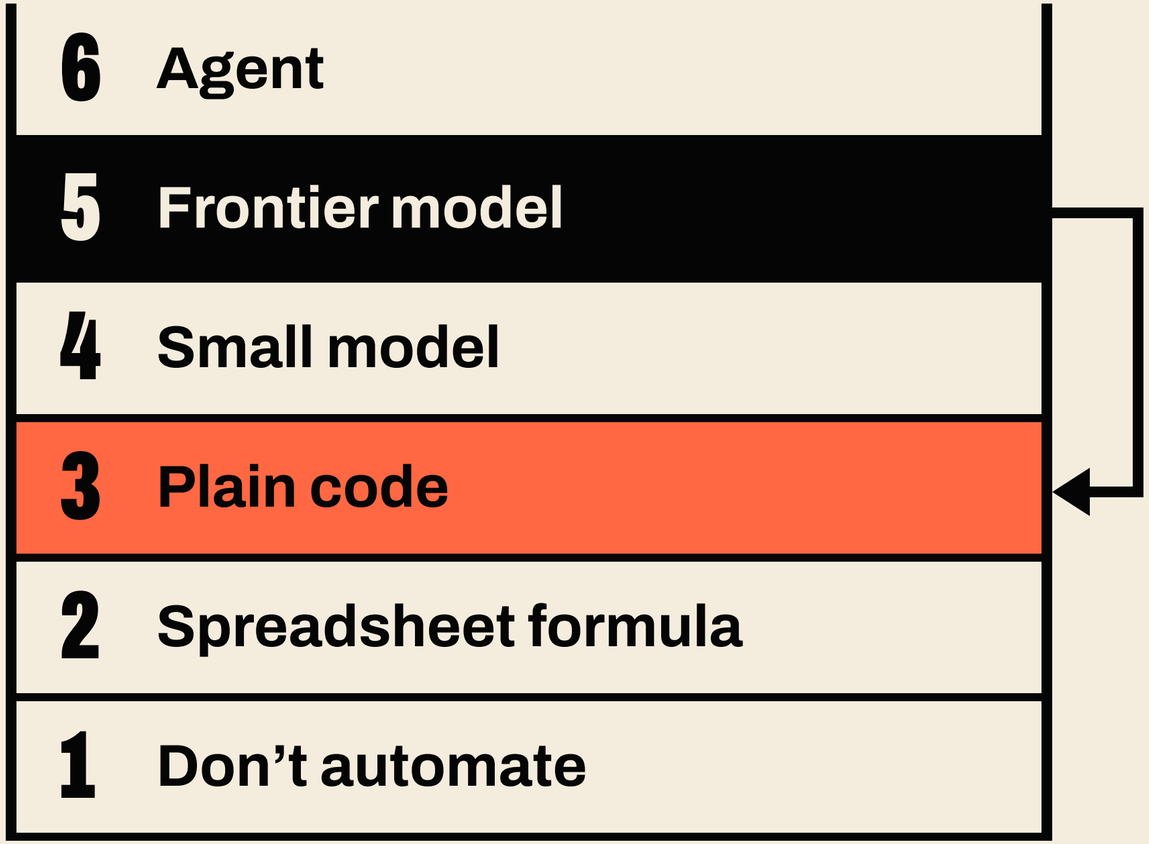
● 5 NOT BEATEN ● 36 BEATEN ○ ESTIMATED PRICE OF ONE TASK · LOG SCALE

Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · the file marks 12 of these 41 scores estimated · rank order is not certain

GATE 1 · COST

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

CLIMB ONLY AS FAR AS THE TASK MAKES YOU.



Use the expensive model once, to write the tool.

Then the tool runs for free.

GATE 2 · RETURN · PRODUCT SIDE

COST | **RETURN** | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

DOES CASH COME IN SOONER?

EXAMPLE THE CASH CONVERSION CYCLE · DAYS · DRAWN TO SCALE



60 + 37 − 30 = 67 days

One day off the cycle frees about one day of sales.

EXAMPLE: A $20M DISTRIBUTOR

≈ $54,800 per day

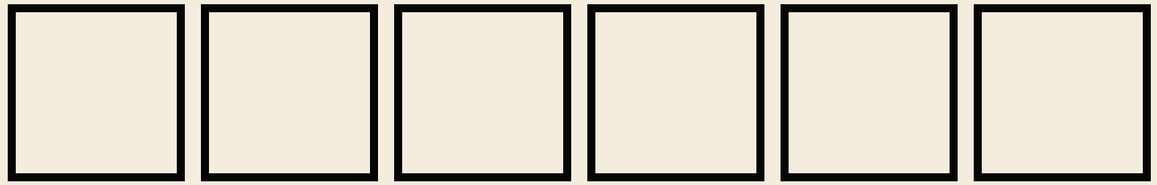
Example figures, not Laborde's · 60 days of inventory + 37 to collect − 30 to pay · one day of sales = annual revenue ÷ 365

GATE 2 · RETURN · SERVICE SIDE

COST | **RETURN** | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

Time is money. Literally.

FREED EVERY WEEK · SAME CREW



0 of 6 hours a week become paid work

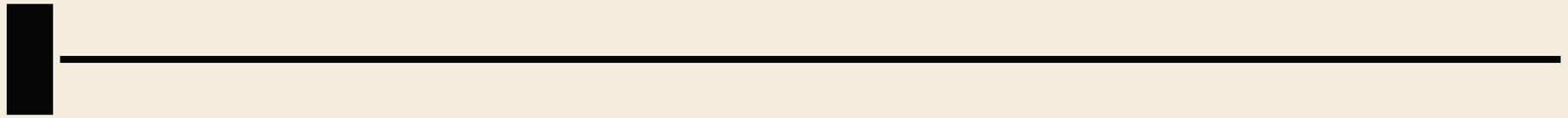
PAID WORK · PER YEAR

EXAMPLE

$0

6 h × 50 weeks × $95 margin × **0%**

HOW MUCH OF THE FREED TIME BECOMES PAID WORK?



0%

Zero is also a decision.

Example figures, not Laborde's · 6 freed hours a week × 50 work weeks = 300 hours a year · $95 margin on a billed hour

GATE 2 · RETURN

COST | **RETURN** | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

DOES IT TOUCH THE CASH PATH?

EXAMPLE

QUOTE → ORDER → PICK → SHIP → **INVOICE** → COLLECT

OFF THE PATH · 20 MINUTES SAVED

INTERNAL MEMOS

1 Labor

– Nothing else

COUNTS ONCE. *Maybe.*

ON THE PATH · 20 MINUTES SAVED

INVOICING

1 Labor

2 Cash sooner

COUNTS TWICE.

The boring idea on the cash path beats the exciting one off it.

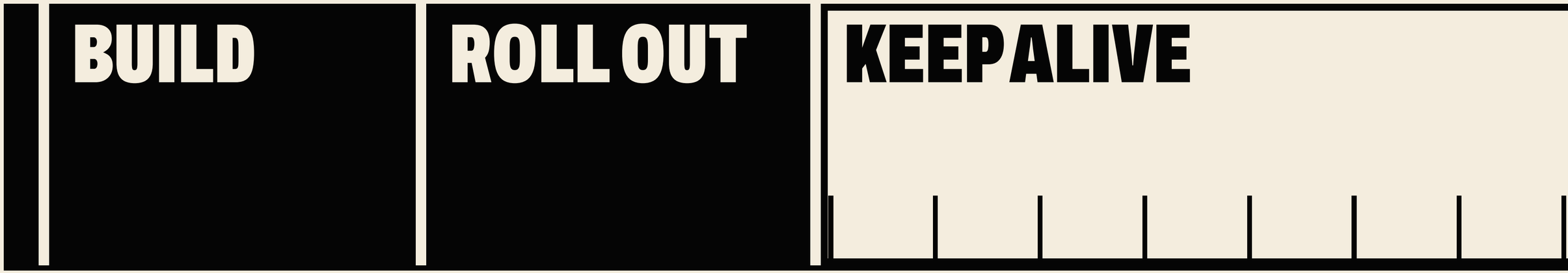
GATE 3 · EFFORT

COST | RETURN | **EFFORT** | POTENTIAL

THE DEMO IS THE CHEAP PART.

ILLUSTRATION, NOT DATA

the demo



Once. Once. Every month.

the part that never ends.

GATE 4 · POTENTIAL

COST | RETURN | EFFORT | **POTENTIAL**

IF IT WORKS, HOW FAR DOES IT GROW?

BUILD EFFORT

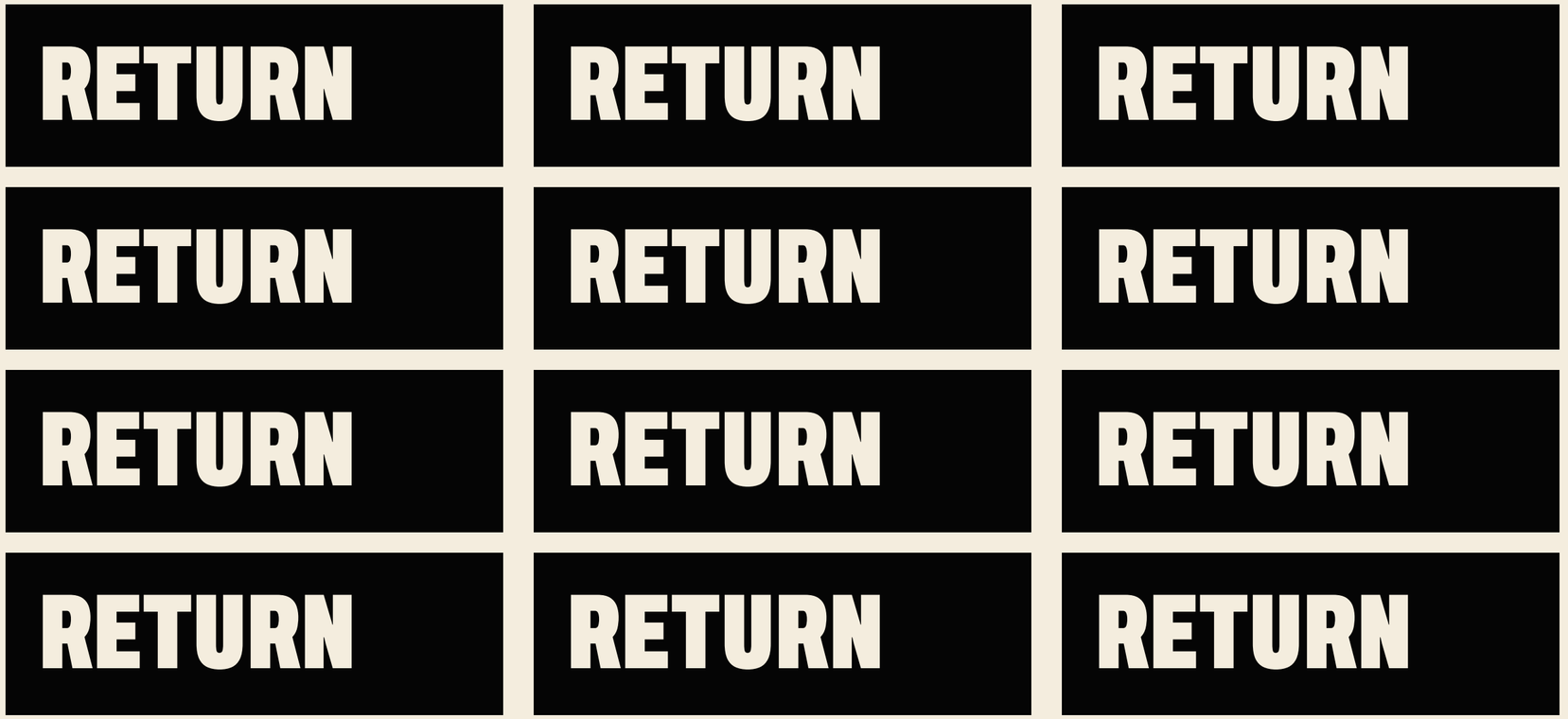
ONCE

Growth multiplies return, not build effort.

- [ ] **Who owns the freed time?**

THREE SITES · EVERY TEAM

ILLUSTRATION, NOT DATA



LET THE MATH PICK.

RETURN – COST – EFFORT *then grown by* POTENTIAL

A MINUTE A WEEK IS

$25

A YEAR.

at $30 an hour · 50 work weeks a year

HOUSE RULES · DEFAULTS · CHANGE THEM

COST	**NO** when yearly cost is more than **30%** of yearly return.
RETURN	**NO** when yearly return is under **$5,000** and it takes no days off the cash cycle.
EFFORT	**NO** when payback is longer than **26** weeks.
POTENTIAL	**NO** when growth is below **1×** or nobody owns the freed time.

EXERCISE 1 · 10 MINUTES

INVENTORY TWO WEEKS OF REAL WORK.

1 What did you do more than twice?

2 What did you copy from one place to another?

3 What did you wait on?

4 What did you dread?

10:00

T start · R reset

EXERCISE 2 · 5 MINUTES

PICK THREE.

1 One you’d love to pitch

2 One that’s boring

3 One you’d be embarrassed to bring up

5:00

T start · R reset

THREE CANDIDATES, FOUR GATES.

EXAMPLE CANDIDATES

A · THE EXCITING ONE
Customer chatbot for parts lookup
NO AT EFFORT

B · THE EASY ONE
Meeting-notes summaries for managers
NO AT COST

C · THE BORING ONE
Invoice follow-up reminders
PASSES ALL FOUR

PASS

GATE 1
COST
$1.35 A YEAR
Under 1% of return

PASS

GATE 2
RETURN
$9,000 A YEAR

PASS

GATE 3
EFFORT
ABOUT 15 WEEKS TO PAY BACK

PASS

GATE 4
POTENTIAL
1.5× GROWTH, OWNER NAMED

PAYS BACK IN
about **15 WEEKS**

WORTH OVER TWO YEARS
about **$17,500**

CASH FREED, ONE TIME
about **$109,600**

Example candidates · time at $30 an hour · building at $75 an hour · cash freed is 2 days of sales (Example: a $20M distributor)

RUN YOUR THREE THROUGH THE GATES. 10:00

RULES	A EXAMPLE	B EXAMPLE	C EXAMPLE
RESET	Customer chatbot for parts lookup	Meeting-notes summaries for managers	Invoice follow-up reminders
COST	PASS — $3,270 a year, 22% of return	NO — $2,880 a year, 58% of return	PASS — $1.35 a year, under 1% of return
RETURN	PASS — $15,000 a year	NOT YET	PASS — $9,000 a year
EFFORT	NO — never pays back	NOT YET	PASS — about 15 weeks to pay back
POTENTIAL	NOT YET	NOT YET	PASS — 1.5× growth, owner named
THE MATH PICKS	Out at Effort	Out at Cost	**$17,547** over two years Frees about $109,600, one time

Minutes saved each time: − 4 +

Times a week: − 150 +

What runs it $0.036 a run: ‹ Frontier model ›

Tools, a month: − $ 250 +

Build and rollout hours: − 440 +

Upkeep hours a month: − 30 +

Growth over a year: − 1.5 × +

Owner for the freed time: YES / NO

Product or service: PRODUCT / SERVICE

On the cash path: YES / NO

House rules, yours to change. NO when yearly cost is more than 30% of yearly return. NO when yearly return is under $5,000 and it takes no days off the cash cycle. NO when payback is longer than 26 weeks. NO when growth is below 1× or nobody owns the freed time. Time at $30 an hour, building at $75, 50 weeks a year. A run is 2,000 tokens in, 500 out, at BenchLM prices.

SHARE-OUT · 5 MINUTES

Who killed their favorite?

Who's keeping the boring one?

5:00

T start · R reset

LABORDE PROJECT RECORDS

The one we built: where the parts live.

Warehouse slotting. Nobody pitches this.

6,493

parts were moving to a new building.

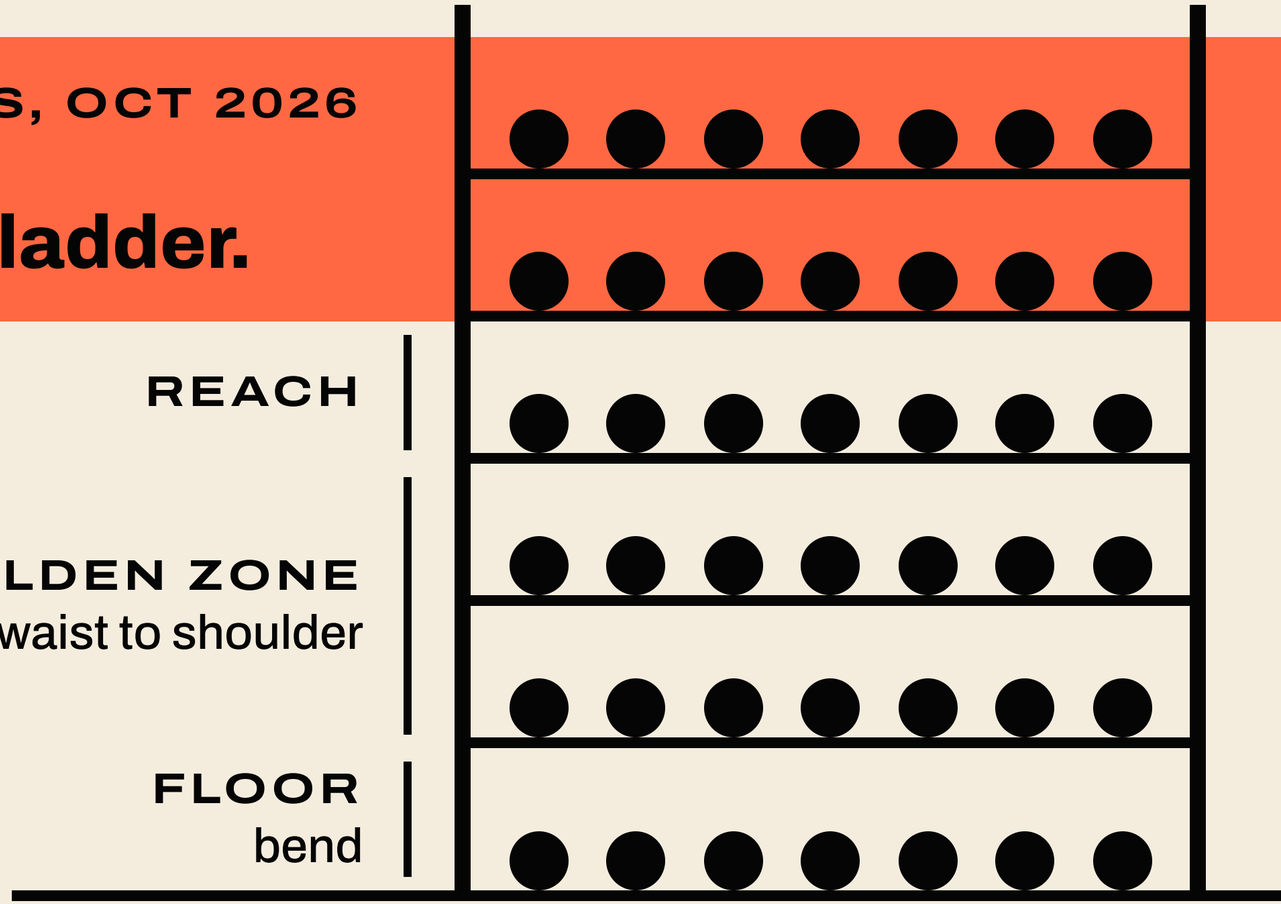
Every one needed an address.

6,493 PARTS. 7,110 SLOTS.

Move them across in their current order and

23% LABORDE RESULTS, OCT 2026

of picks need a ladder.

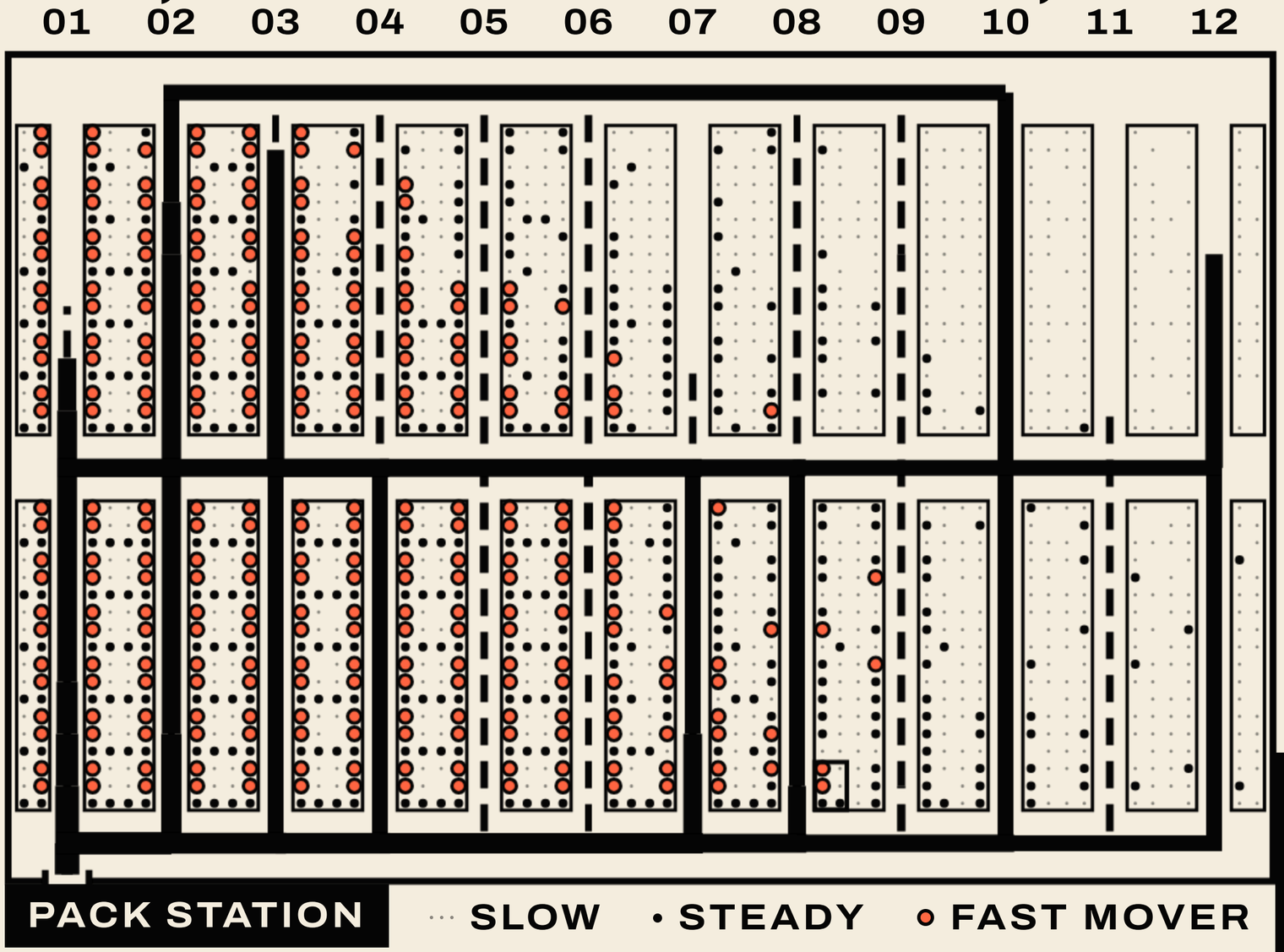


Laborde results, Oct 2026

RACK DRAWING: ILLUSTRATION

ANIMATED RE-CREATION · SYNTHETIC DATA

240,000 SWAPS TRIED IN 2,371 MS.



	AS-IS MOVE	OPTIMIZED
Walk per pick run	291	→ 141 ft
Pick time per year	77.4	→ 27.8 hours
Picks that need a ladder	36%	→ 1.7%
Fast movers in the golden zone	32%	→ 100%

NO AI MODEL IN THE LOOP.

THE REAL NUMBERS.

LABORDE RESULTS, OCT 2026

	AS-IS MOVE		OPTIMIZED	
Walk per pick run	133.6 ft	→	91.1 ft	*31.8% less*
Pick time per year	32.8 hours	→	17.4 hours	*47.0% less*
Picks that need a ladder	23%	→	0.6%	
Fast movers in the golden zone	39%	→	100%	

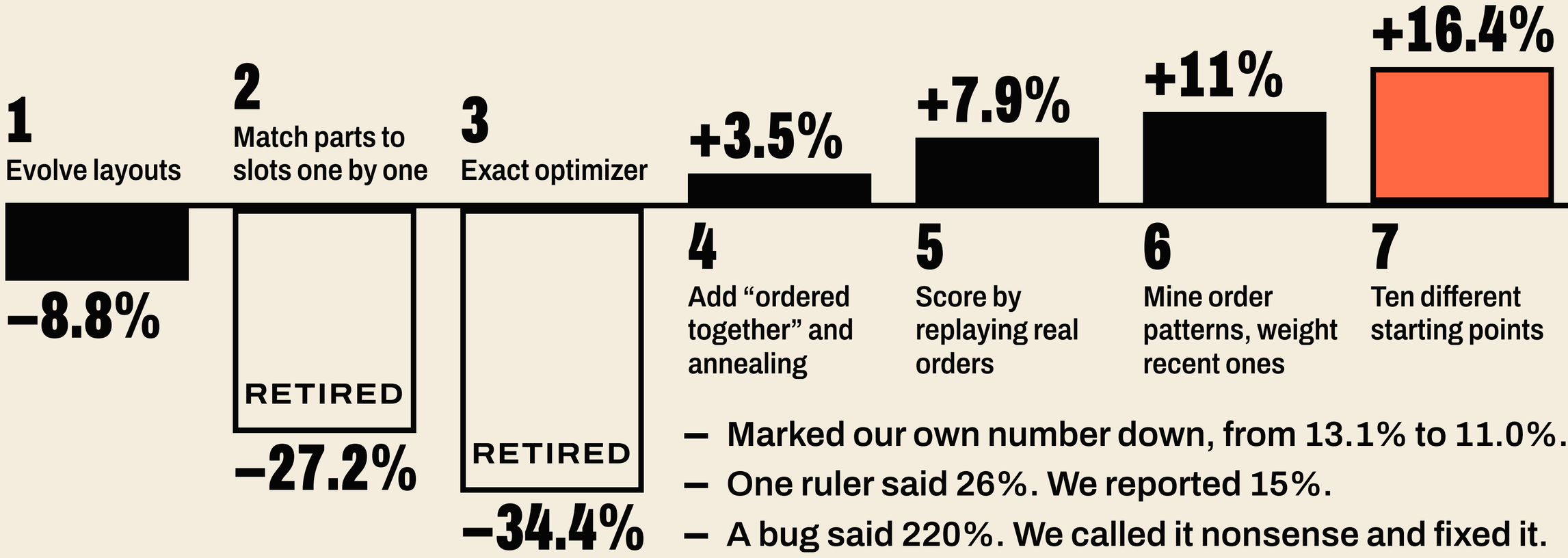
OPTIMIZED, VERSUS THE OLD BUILDING TODAY

12.3% less walking **22.7%** less pick time *In a bigger building.*

Laborde results, Oct 27–28, 2026 · versus moving every part in its current order · pick times are placeholders pending a floor time study
results depend on where the pack station is · the old building's floor plan is estimated

SEVEN ATTEMPTS. THE FIRST THREE LOST TO THE OLD BUILDING.

PERCENT LESS WALKING · ZERO IS THE OLD BUILDING · DRAWN TO SCALE



- Marked our own number down, from 13.1% to 11.0%.
- One ruler said 26%. We reported 15%.
- A bug said 220%. We called it nonsense and fixed it.

The gains came from measuring real orders, not from fancier solvers.

Laborde project records · Walking versus the old building, March 2026 model

WHAT WE SAID NO TO.

LABORDE PROJECT RECORDS

AN AI MODEL IN THE LOOP

It didn’t fit the problem.

NO

A FANCIER SOLVER

Tried two. Both lost.

NO

RE-SLOTTING EVERY MONTH

The move is the one free re-slot.

NO

A $500,000-A-YEAR SAVINGS CLAIM

No source. Excluded.

NO

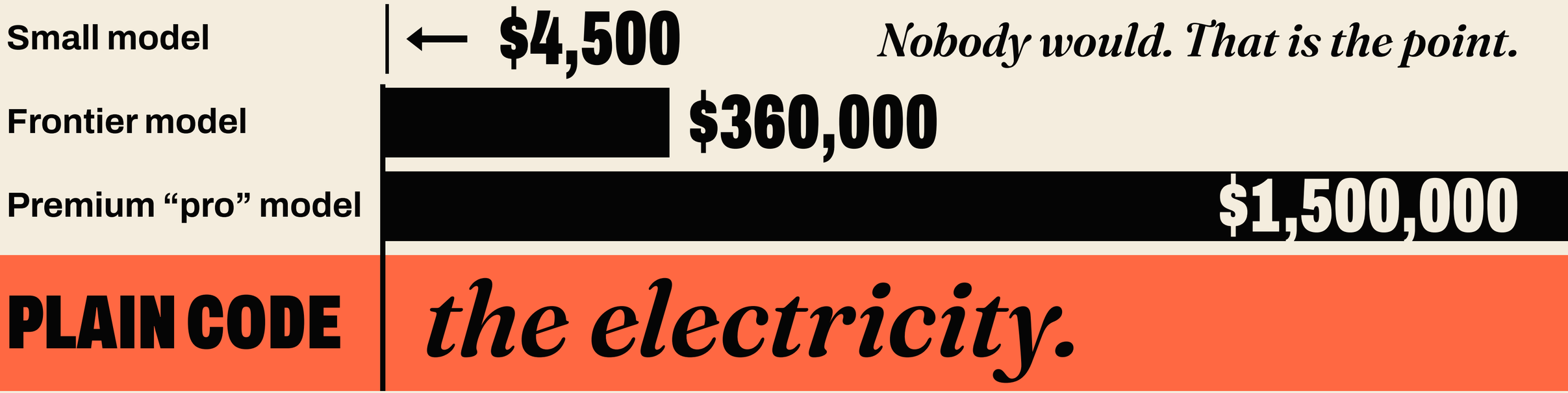
COST | RETURN | EFFORT | POTENTIAL

WHAT IT COSTS TO RUN: NOTHING.

33 of 47 commits co-written with AI · **0** AI models at run time · **10 million** swaps in about 3.5 minutes

If each of those 10 million tries were a model call:

EXAMPLE · COST OF ONE RUN · US DOLLARS · BARS DRAWN TO SCALE



PLAIN CODE *the electricity.*

The model’s job was to help write the tool. Not to be the tool.

Laborde project records, Mar–Nov 2026 · Source: BenchLM leaderboard export, November 2026 · tiers: Claude Haiku 5.5, Claude Fable 5.2, GPT-5.5 Pro · 2,000 tokens in / 500 out per call

MY OWN PROJECT, THROUGH MY OWN GATES.

The move was the one free re-slot.

PASS

COST

$0 to run

→

RETURN

ON MINUTES ALONE

15.4 hours a year

= $462

NO

UNDER $5,000,
AND NO CASH SOONER

EFFORT

NOT YET

POTENTIAL

NOT YET

CARRIED FORWARD

Laborde results, Oct 2026 · 15.4 hours = 32.8 – 17.4 pick hours a year · valued at $30 an hour, an example rate

We just got the minutes back.

Who owns them?

THE OBJECTION

“My people will just waste the time.”

THAT’S A MANAGEMENT ANSWER. IT ISN’T AN AI PROBLEM.

MY VIEW

SHARE THE GAIN.

1

Name the goal for the freed time

2

Measure it

3

Share the upside

People hide time savings that threaten them. They report the ones they share in.

THE WAYPOINT STANDARD

1	2	3	4
THE TASK	THE PROMPT	THE OUTPUT	THE TIME SAVED

If you can’t show all four, it didn’t happen.

MONDAY MORNING.

1 Inventory two weeks.

2 Run three through the gates.

3 Say **NO** twice.

"A few first rate
~~research papers~~ **AI PROJECTS** OUR EDIT
are preferable to a large number
that are poorly conceived
or half-finished."

— CLAUDE SHANNON, THE BANDWAGON, 1956

SAY NO TO THE EXCITING.
SAY YES TO THE MATH.

SAY NO TO THE EXCITING. SAY YES TO THE MATH.

Thank you.

Questions.

Dustin T Hughes

VP of Technology, Laborde Products